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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The **1906 San Francisco Earthquake** was a catastrophic event that profoundly reshaped both the city and the Bay Area's landscape. It occurred on **April 18, 1906**, along the **San Andreas Fault**, with an estimated magnitude of **7.8**. The earthquake itself caused widespread structural damage, but it was the **fires that broke out afterward** that devastated much of San Francisco. These fires burned for several days, destroying large swaths of the city, including homes, businesses, and infrastructure. Official estimates report that **over 3,000 people died**, and more than **half of the city's population was left homeless**.

Several factors shaped the current landscape of San Francisco after the earthquake:

1. **Urban Rebuilding and Zoning** – The reconstruction offered an opportunity to modernize infrastructure. Streets were widened, utilities improved, and building codes were updated to better resist earthquakes. Many iconic neighborhoods, like the **Financial District**, were rebuilt with sturdier materials.
2. **Land Use Changes** – Some areas previously developed on unstable landfill or reclaimed land were redesigned or abandoned due to heightened awareness of seismic risk. This reshaped the city's footprint and influenced later urban planning.
3. **Topographical Awareness** – The earthquake and resulting fires highlighted the vulnerabilities of hilly terrain and fill areas. Today, San Francisco's zoning and construction practices reflect lessons learned about soil stability and fault proximity.
4. **Social and Economic Shifts** – The disaster accelerated demographic changes and the migration of communities within the city. Many displaced residents moved to outlying areas, influencing suburban growth around the Bay Area.
5. **Seismic Preparedness** – The earthquake cemented San Francisco's role as a hub for seismology and earthquake engineering. Policies, building codes, and public awareness campaigns today stem directly from lessons of 1906.

In short, the 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy buildings—it reshaped the **physical, social, and regulatory landscape** of San Francisco, influencing the city's resilience and urban form for over a century.

If you want, I can also make a **visual map showing pre- and post-1906 changes** to the city landscape—it really highlights how the disaster reshaped neighborhoods.

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